



ARSI UNIVERSITY

COLLEGE OF SOCIAL SCIENCE AND HUMANITIES

DEPARTMENT OF SOCIOLOGY AND SOCIAL WORK

Group Assignment

The Role of Indigenous Mutual Support Systems in Community Welfare: A Mixed Methods Research Proposal

Geographic Focus: Assela City and Surrounding Rural Kebeles, Arsi Zone, Oromia, Ethiopia

Researchers: By Group of 10 Students

Program: Bachelor of Arts in Sociology and Social Work Third Year

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A Note from Group Member

This proposal is born from what we observe in our communities every day. As students of sociology and social work, we witness how traditional mutual support systems such as Iddir, Debo, Wonfel, and Iqub continue to function alongside modern social welfare structures. At the same time, we see these indigenous systems facing pressures from urbanization, economic change, and shifting social values. This research proposal is our attempt to understand the contemporary role of these indigenous institutions in promoting community welfare and to explore how social work practice can effectively collaborate with them.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

We would like to express our sincere gratitude to our instructor for providing valuable guidance and encouragement during the preparation of this research proposal. We also extend our appreciation to the Department of Sociology and Social Work, Arsi University, for creating a supportive academic environment that promotes learning and research.

We are thankful to all group members for their cooperation, commitment, and teamwork throughout the development of this proposal. Finally, we acknowledge the authors and researchers whose works have contributed to the preparation of this study. Thank you.

ABSTRACT

This research proposal will examine the role of indigenous mutual support systems (Iddir, Debo, Wonfel, and Iqub) in promoting community welfare in Assela City and surrounding rural kebeles of Arsi Zone, Oromia, Ethiopia. The study will investigate the welfare benefits, challenges, and contemporary relevance of these indigenous institutions.

A mixed methods research design will be employed. Quantitative data will be collected through household surveys, while qualitative data will be gathered through interviews, focus group discussions, and document review. The collected data will be analyzed using statistical and thematic analysis techniques.

The study is expected to generate evidence on the contribution of indigenous mutual support systems to community welfare and will provide recommendations for strengthening collaboration between indigenous institutions and social work practice.

Keywords: Indigenous Mutual Support Systems, Iddir, Debo, Wonfel, Iqub, Community Welfare, Social Work

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Acronym

- **IMSS – Indigenous Mutual Support Systems**
- **FGD – Focus Group Discussion**
- **IDI – In-Depth Interview**
- **NGO – Non-Governmental Organization**
- **SPSS – Statistical Package for the Social Sciences**
- **ETB – Ethiopian Birr**
- **PSNP – Productive Safety Net Program**
- **SSA – Sub-Saharan Africa (if mentioned)**
- **SW – Social Work (if abbreviated in the text)**
- **H1 – Hypothesis 1**
- **H2 – Hypothesis 2**
- **H3 – Hypothesis 3**
- **H4 – Hypothesis 4**
- **H5 – Hypothesis 5**

CHAPTER ONE: INTRODUCTION

1.1 Background of the Study

Indigenous mutual support systems have existed in Ethiopia for centuries as community-based mechanisms for solidarity and risk sharing. In Oromo society and other ethnic groups in the Arsi Zone, traditional institutions such as Iddir (funeral and emergency assistance), Debo (labor sharing among farming families), Wonfel (large-scale collective work parties), and Iqub (rotating savings and credit associations) have served as the backbone of community welfare long before formal social welfare systems were established. These systems operate on principles of reciprocity, trust, and shared responsibility.

However, rapid urbanization, economic transformation, and the expansion of formal social services have created both challenges and opportunities for these indigenous systems. Some scholars argue that traditional support mechanisms are eroding, while others suggest they are adapting and remaining resilient. In Assela City and its surrounding rural areas, these systems coexist with government social protection programs, religious charities, and emerging NGO interventions. Understanding how these indigenous systems function today and how they interact with formal welfare structures is critical for developing culturally appropriate and effective social work practice.

This mixed methods research proposal aims to systematically investigate the role of indigenous mutual support systems in community welfare from a social work perspective. The study will be conducted in Assela City and selected rural kebeles of Arsi Zone, focusing on how Iddir, Debo, Wonfel, and Iqub contribute to household welfare, social cohesion, and community resilience. The findings will inform recommendations for social workers and policymakers on how to partner with these indigenous institutions.

In addition to Iddir, Debo, Wonfel, and Iqub, recent scholarship has identified 'Dabaree' as a distinct Arsi Oromo indigenous practice involving the offering of milking cows or other resources to poor community members who lack possessions. As Kedir, Samuel, and Adem (2024) document, Dabaree represents an indigenous resource-sharing tradition that ensures the poor can enjoy decent living standards and embodies the Arsi Oromo philosophy that 'solidarity with the poor is a blessed act.'"

1.2 Statement of the Problem

The core problem this proposal addresses is the lack of systematic understanding about the contemporary role and effectiveness of indigenous mutual support systems in community welfare within the Assela area, and the absence of clear guidelines for how social work practice can effectively engage with these traditional institutions.

First, there is limited empirical research documenting how indigenous mutual support systems currently function in the Arsi Zone. While historical and anthropological studies exist, contemporary data on membership patterns, benefit distributions, challenges, and adaptations are scarce.

Second, there is a disconnect between formal social welfare services and indigenous support systems. Social workers and government programs often operate parallel to these traditional institutions without understanding their strengths, limitations, or potential for collaboration.

Third, rapid social changes including youth migration, market integration, and individualization of livelihoods may be affecting the sustainability and reach of these mutual support systems. Some community members may be excluded or underserved by traditional arrangements.

Fourth, there is no evidence-based framework for social workers to assess when and how to partner with indigenous mutual support systems versus when to provide alternative interventions.

This gap represents a missed opportunity for culturally grounded social work practice that builds on community strengths rather than replacing them. Without this understanding, social welfare interventions risk being culturally inappropriate, inefficient, or even disruptive to existing community coping mechanisms.

1.3 Research Questions

This study will answer the following primary research question and its sub-questions.

Primary Research Question: What is the contemporary role of indigenous mutual support systems (specifically Iddir, Debo, Wonfel, and Iqub) in promoting community welfare in Assela City and surrounding rural kebeles, and how can social work practice effectively engage with these systems?

Specific Sub-Questions:

1. What are the current structures, membership patterns, and operational mechanisms of indigenous mutual support systems in the study areas?
2. What types of welfare benefits (both material and non-material) do members receive from participation in these systems?
3. What challenges do these indigenous mutual support systems face in the contemporary context, including pressures from urbanization, economic change, and formal institutions?
4. How do community members and social welfare professionals perceive the relationship between indigenous support systems and formal social welfare services?

1.4 Objectives of the Study

1.4.1 General Objective

To examine the role of indigenous mutual support systems (Iddir, Debo, Wonfel, and Iqub) in community welfare in Assela City and surrounding rural kebeles, and to develop evidence-based recommendations for integrating these systems into culturally competent social work practice.

1.4.2 Specific Objectives

1. To describe the current structures, membership characteristics, governance mechanisms, and operational procedures of indigenous mutual support systems operating in the study areas.
2. To assess the types and extent of welfare benefits provided to members by these indigenous systems, including emergency assistance, social security, livelihood support, and psychosocial benefits.
3. To identify the major challenges confronting indigenous mutual support systems in the contemporary context, including internal and external pressures.
4. To explore the perceptions of community members, system leaders, and social welfare professionals regarding the relationship and potential collaboration between indigenous systems and formal social welfare services.
5. To propose practical strategies for social workers to effectively assess, respect, and partner with indigenous mutual support systems in community welfare interventions.

1.5 Research Hypotheses (Quantitative Component)

Based on the research objectives and literature review, the following hypotheses will be tested in the quantitative phase:

H1: Households that participate in indigenous mutual support systems (Iddir, Debo, Wonfel, or Iqub) will have significantly higher welfare index scores compared to non-participating households.

H2: Frequency of participation in indigenous systems is positively correlated with perceived household wellbeing.

H3: Rural households will report higher levels of participation in Debo and Wonfel compared to urban households.

H4: Female-headed households will show higher rates of Iqub participation compared to male-headed households.

H5: Perceived erosion of indigenous systems will be greater among younger respondents (age 18-30) compared to older respondents (age 50+).

1.6 Significance of the Study

This research holds significance for multiple audiences. For the community members of Assela City and surrounding rural kebeles, this study will document and validate the contributions of their traditional institutions, potentially strengthening these systems through recognition and support. For social work students and practitioners at Arsi University and beyond, this research will provide a culturally grounded framework for practice that builds on community strengths rather than imposing external models. For policymakers in the Assela City Administration and Oromia Regional Social Affairs Bureau, the findings will offer evidence on how to align formal social protection programs with existing community mechanisms. For the academic community, this study will contribute empirical data on the adaptation and resilience of indigenous institutions in contemporary Ethiopia, filling a gap in the literature. For the researchers themselves as sociology and social work students, this project will develop our skills in mixed

methods research, community engagement, and culturally sensitive inquiry which are essential for our future professional careers.

1.7 Scope of the Study

1.7.1 Delimitation (What the Study Will Cover)

Geographic Focus: This study will be conducted in Assela City (specifically selected kebeles within the city) and two surrounding rural kebeles in Arsi Zone to allow comparison between urban and rural contexts.

Topical Focus: The study will focus specifically on four indigenous mutual support systems: Iddir, Debo, Wonfel, and Iqub. It will examine their role in community welfare broadly defined to include material assistance, social support, and psychosocial wellbeing.

Unit of Analysis: The study will collect data from individual members, non-members, system leaders, elders, and social welfare professionals.

Time Frame: This research covers the proposal and design phase. Data collection and analysis would occur over approximately six months in the implementation phase.

1.7.2 Limitations (Potential Challenges)

Time Constraints: As students, our time for comprehensive fieldwork is limited to academic schedules.

Resource Limits: This is a proposal for a research study. Actual implementation would require funding for transportation, transcription, and other field expenses.

Recall Bias: Some participants may have difficulty accurately recalling details of their participation history or benefits received.

Generalization: Findings will be specific to the Assela and Arsi Zone context and may not be directly transferable to other regions.

Access Challenges: Gaining access to system meetings and ensuring participation from busy community members may present logistical challenges.

1.8 Definition of Terms

Dabaree: A traditional Arsi Oromo resource-sharing practice in which community members with resources (traditionally milking cows) offer them temporarily or permanently to poor households, serving as an indigenous poverty alleviation mechanism (Kedir et al., 2024).

1.8.1 Conceptual Definitions

Indigenous Mutual Support System: A community-based institution that emerges from local cultural traditions and operates on principles of reciprocity, shared risk, and collective action to provide support to members.

Iddir: A traditional Ethiopian community-based organization primarily organized for funeral assistance and emergency support, though many Iddirs have expanded to provide broader welfare services.

Debo: A traditional Oromo labor sharing system in which farming families take turns working on each other's land, typically during peak agricultural seasons.

Wonfel: A larger-scale collective work party in Oromo tradition that mobilizes a wider community for intensive agricultural tasks, often accompanied by food sharing and social celebration.

Iqub: A rotating savings and credit association in which members contribute a fixed amount of money at regular intervals and each member receives the full collected sum on a rotating basis.

Community Welfare: The wellbeing of community members as reflected in their access to material resources, social support networks, emotional security, and ability to cope with shocks and crises.

1.8.2 Operational Definitions (How This Study Will Use These Terms)

For the purpose of this research, indigenous mutual support system refers specifically to Iddir, Debo, Wonfel, or Iqub that have been operating for at least one year in the study areas and have five or more active members.

Member refers to an individual aged eighteen years or older who currently participates in at least one of these systems and has made contributions within the past six months.

Welfare Benefit refers to any form of assistance received by a member including direct financial payment, labor received, food or goods received during ceremonies, emotional support during crisis, or access to credit through Iqub.

Social Work Perspective refers to the professional orientation that values community strengths, cultural competence, systems thinking, and the ethical principle of respecting indigenous helping traditions.

CHAPTER TWO: REVIEW OF RELATED LITERATURE AND CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORK

2.1 Theoretical Underpinnings

This research is grounded in three interconnected theoretical perspectives that together provide a comprehensive lens for understanding indigenous mutual support systems and their relevance to social work practice.

2.1.1 Social Capital Theory

Social capital theory, as developed by scholars including Pierre Bourdieu, James Coleman, and Robert Putnam, emphasizes that social networks, trust, norms of reciprocity, and shared values are resources that individuals and communities can draw upon to achieve collective action and mutual benefit. Indigenous mutual support systems are quintessential examples of social capital in action. Membership in Iddir, Debo, Wonfel, or Iqub creates bonding social capital among members who share similar circumstances and bridging social capital that connects diverse community members across kinship or economic lines.

Link to this Research: This study will use social capital theory to understand how participation in indigenous systems generates trust, cooperation, and collective welfare outcomes. We will examine whether higher levels of social capital (measured through network density, trust, and reciprocity) are associated with better welfare outcomes.

2.1.2 Indigenization of Social Work Theory

The indigenization of social work theory argues that social work practice must be adapted to local cultural contexts rather than imposing Western models. Scholars have critiqued the transfer of Northern social work frameworks to Southern contexts and have called for developing culturally relevant practice approaches that build on indigenous helping systems. This perspective recognizes that communities have existing strengths, resources, and helping traditions that should be respected and supported rather than replaced by formal social services.

Link to this Research: This theory directly informs our research questions about how social workers can collaborate with indigenous mutual support systems. Rather than viewing traditional systems as backward or needing modernization, we will explore how social work can adopt an assets-based approach that partners with these systems to enhance community welfare.

2.1.3 Systems Theory

Systems theory, widely used in social work, views communities as complex systems with interdependent parts. Changes in one part of the system affect other parts. From this perspective, indigenous mutual support systems, formal social welfare programs, religious charities, government services, and market mechanisms are all subsystems that interact within the larger community welfare system. Understanding these interactions is essential for effective intervention.

Link to this Research: Systems theory guides our analysis of how indigenous mutual support systems relate to other welfare mechanisms. We will examine whether these systems complement, compete with, or are being displaced by formal services. This perspective prevents us from studying indigenous systems in isolation and instead situates them within the broader welfare ecology.

2.2 Review of Related Literature

2.2.1 Indigenous Mutual Support Systems in Ethiopia:

Historical and Contemporary Perspectives

Historical and anthropological literature documents that indigenous mutual support systems have been central to Ethiopian community life for centuries. Researchers have described Iddir as one of the most ubiquitous forms of community-based organization in Ethiopia, with studies estimating that the majority of urban and rural households belong to at least one Iddir. The primary function of Iddir has traditionally been funeral assistance—providing money, materials, and labor for burial ceremonies. However, contemporary studies suggest that many Iddirs have expanded their welfare functions to include support for members facing illness, accident, house fires, or other emergencies.

Debo and Wonfel have been extensively documented among Oromo farming communities as traditional labor sharing arrangements that enable households to accomplish agricultural tasks that would be

impossible for a single nuclear family. These systems also serve social functions, reinforcing community bonds and providing opportunities for sharing food and information.

Iqub has been studied as a financial innovation that allows low-income individuals to access lump sums for major expenses such as school fees, medical treatment, home improvement, or business investment. Research indicates that Iqub participation is particularly important for women and informal sector workers who lack access to formal credit.

However, a notable gap in this literature is the relative lack of recent empirical studies from the Arsi Zone specifically. Most existing research is either dated or conducted in other regions of Ethiopia. This study will contribute contemporary data from Assela and surrounding areas.

2.2.2 The Impact of Social Change on Indigenous Support Systems

Scholars have documented multiple pressures affecting indigenous mutual support systems in contemporary Ethiopia. Urbanization has been identified as a double-edged sword. On one hand, urban contexts may weaken traditional systems as neighbors are less familiar with each other and migration disrupts stable membership. On the other hand, urban vulnerability may increase demand for mutual support, leading to adaptation and innovation.

Economic changes including market integration, commercialization of agriculture, and the expansion of wage labor have been shown to affect Debo and Wonfel systems. As farmers increasingly hire labor rather than relying on reciprocal exchanges, the labor sharing ethic may erode. However, some studies suggest that Debo adapts, shifting from pure reciprocity to arrangements that combine reciprocity with cash payments.

Demographic changes including youth out-migration from rural areas have been identified as a threat to labor-intensive systems like Debo and Wonfel which depend on a robust supply of working-age adults. Additionally, the expansion of formal social protection programs and microfinance institutions may be competing with indigenous systems, though evidence on displacement versus complementarity is mixed.

The key gap in this literature is the lack of studies that simultaneously examine multiple systems (Iddir, Debo, Wonfel, and Iqub) in the same geographic area using a mixed methods design that captures both quantitative patterns and qualitative experiences. This study addresses that gap.

2.2.3 Social Work and Indigenous Helping Systems

A growing body of literature in international social work addresses the relationship between professional social work and indigenous helping traditions. Scholars have argued that Western social work education often ignores or devalues indigenous systems, leading to practice that is culturally inappropriate and ineffective. In the Ethiopian context, some researchers have called for indigenizing social work curricula and practice to better align with local realities. However, there are few empirical studies that document successful collaborations between social workers and indigenous mutual support systems. This gap means that social workers lack evidence-based guidance on when and how to engage with Iddir, Debo, Wonfel, or Iqub. This study will contribute to filling that gap.

2.3 Conceptual Framework

This study is guided by a conceptual framework that integrates the three theoretical perspectives into a coherent model for understanding indigenous mutual support systems and their relationship to community welfare and social work practice.

The framework begins with the recognition that communities in Assela and surrounding areas have existing indigenous mutual support systems (Iddir, Debo, Wonfel, and Iqub) that have emerged from local cultural traditions. These systems are characterized by specific structures including membership criteria, governance mechanisms, contribution requirements, and benefit rules. These structures are shaped by and shape the social capital within the community, including trust, networks, and norms of reciprocity.

The indigenous mutual support systems produce multiple welfare outcomes for members, including material benefits (cash, food, labor, credit) and non-material benefits (social support, emotional security, sense of belonging, resilience to shocks). However, these systems do not operate in isolation. They exist within a broader welfare environment that includes formal social welfare services (government programs, NGOs, religious charities) and market mechanisms.

The interactions between indigenous systems and formal systems can be: complementary (filling each other's gaps), competitive (overlap creating duplication or tension), or substitutional (formal services displacing indigenous systems). Social workers, as professionals operating within this welfare ecology, have choices about how to engage with indigenous systems.

Four possible engagement strategies can be identified: (1) ignoring indigenous systems and working only through formal channels; (2) replacing indigenous systems with formal interventions; (3) competing with indigenous systems for resources and clients; or (4) collaborating with indigenous systems through respectful partnership. This study aims to understand which engagement strategies are most appropriate under what conditions, from the perspectives of both community members and social welfare professionals. The ultimate goal is to develop recommendations for culturally competent social work practice that builds on community strengths.

CHAPTER THREE: RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

3.1 Research Design

This study will employ a mixed methods research design combining quantitative and qualitative approaches within a single investigation. A mixed methods design is appropriate for this research because the research questions have both quantitative dimensions (such as measuring membership rates, benefit frequencies, and correlations between participation and welfare outcomes) and qualitative dimensions (such as understanding lived experiences, cultural meanings, and stakeholder perspectives).

The specific mixed methods design will be a convergent parallel design. In this design, quantitative and qualitative data will be collected separately but simultaneously during the same phase of the research. Each type of data will be analyzed independently. The quantitative analysis will produce statistical findings about patterns and relationships. The qualitative analysis will produce thematic findings about meanings and processes. The two sets of findings will then be merged during the interpretation phase to

compare, contrast, and integrate the results. The purpose of this convergence is to achieve a more complete and validated understanding than either method could provide alone.

This design aligns with our training in sociology and social work which values both empirical measurement and deep contextual understanding. The research approaches are both quantitative (household survey) and qualitative (interviews and focus groups). Methods of data analysis will include SPSS version 26 for Windows for quantitative statistical analysis (descriptive statistics, cross-tabulations with chi-square tests, independent samples t-tests, ANOVA, and multiple linear regression). Qualitative data will be analyzed using thematic analysis following the six-phase approach of Braun and Clarke. Excel will be used for basic data organization and for creating simple charts and graphs to visualize quantitative findings.

3.2 Study Area and Context

The study will be conducted in Assela City, the administrative capital of Arsi Zone, and two surrounding rural kebeles selected for comparison. Assela City is an urban center with a mixed economy including government services, trade, manufacturing, and agriculture. The city has a diverse population including people from multiple ethnic and religious backgrounds. Assela is also home to Arsi University, which creates a unique context with a significant student population and educated professionals.

The two rural kebeles will be selected based on consultation with the Arsi Zone Agriculture and Rural Development Office. Selection criteria will include: distance from Assela City (one kebele within ten kilometers and one kebele twenty to thirty kilometers away), predominant livelihood patterns (mixed farming versus crop-focused), and presence of active indigenous mutual support systems as confirmed by key informants. This urban-rural comparison will allow the study to examine how context shapes the functioning of indigenous support systems.

3.3 Sampling Strategy and Participants

This study will use a combination of probability and purposive sampling techniques appropriate for the mixed methods design.

For the quantitative survey component, we will use stratified random sampling. The sampling frame will consist of households in Assela City selected kebeles and the two rural kebeles. The strata will be urban kebeles and rural kebeles. Within each stratum, households will be randomly selected using a computer-generated random number sequence applied to household lists obtained from kebele administration offices.

The target sample size for the quantitative survey is 280 households, calculated based on a population proportion estimation formula with 5% margin of error and 95% confidence level, assuming 50% response distribution, and accounting for 10% non-response or incomplete data. Within each selected household, one adult aged eighteen years or older will be invited to participate.

For the qualitative component, we will use purposive sampling to select participants who have specific knowledge or experience relevant to the research questions. Purposive sampling is appropriate because we need to ensure we capture diverse perspectives including those of members, non-members, system leaders, elders, and professionals.

The qualitative sample will include approximately 60 participants distributed as follows:

- 20 individual in-depth interview participants, including: four Iddir leaders, four Debo coordinators, four Wonfel organizers, four Iqub collectors, two community elders knowledgeable about historical changes, and two social welfare professionals from government or NGO settings.
- 4 focus group discussions with approximately 8-10 participants per group, organized as: (1) female members of indigenous systems; (2) male members; (3) youth aged 18-30 who are members or potential members; and (4) non-members or former members to understand barriers to participation.

Participants for the qualitative component will be recruited through snowball sampling starting with key informants from kebele offices and system leaders, and through announcements at community gathering places.

3.4 Data Collection Methods

This study will use four complementary data collection methods to gather both quantitative and qualitative data.

3.4.1 Household Survey

A structured questionnaire will be administered face-to-face to the 280 sampled household heads or adult representatives. The questionnaire will include both closed-ended and limited open-ended questions. The survey will collect data on: household demographic characteristics (age, gender, education, occupation, income, household composition); membership in indigenous systems (current and past membership in Iddir, Debo, Wonfel, and Iqub separately, including duration and frequency); welfare benefits received (specific benefits in past 12 months including cash, labor, food, credit, emotional support); welfare outcomes (household welfare index combining food security, asset ownership, and subjective wellbeing); and perceptions of system effectiveness and challenges (Likert scale items).

The survey will be developed in English, translated to Afan Oromo and Amharic, and back-translated to ensure accuracy. The survey will be piloted with thirty households not included in the final sample to test question clarity, flow, and timing.

3.4.2 In-Depth Interviews

Semi-structured in-depth interviews will be conducted with the twenty purposively selected participants. Each interview will last approximately 45-60 minutes and will be conducted in the participant's preferred language (Afan Oromo, Amharic, or English). The interview guide will cover: for system leaders—history of the system, governance structures, membership rules, contribution and benefit mechanisms, changes over time, current challenges, and relationship with formal institutions; for community elders—historical changes in mutual support systems, traditional values, and perceptions of younger generations' participation; for social welfare professionals—awareness of indigenous systems, current engagement, perceptions of strengths and limitations, and views on potential collaboration.

All interviews will be audio recorded with participant consent. When a participant does not consent to recording, detailed written notes will be taken during and immediately after the interview.

3.4.3 Focus Group Discussions

Four focus group discussions will be conducted with 8-10 participants per group. Each focus group will last approximately 90 minutes and will be facilitated by a member of the research team with a second team member taking notes. The focus group guide will cover: community perceptions of indigenous mutual support systems; shared experiences of benefits and challenges; social dynamics including inclusion and exclusion; generational differences in participation; and ideas for strengthening systems or improving collaboration with formal services.

Focus groups will be audio recorded with participant consent. The group setting allows for discussion, debate, and the emergence of shared community understandings that may not emerge in individual interviews.

3.4.4 Document Review

Existing documents will be reviewed to supplement primary data. Documents will include: membership records from selected Iddirs and Iqubs (if accessible and with consent); kebele administration records on community organizations (if available); policy documents from the Assela City Social Affairs Office regarding community-based welfare; and relevant previous studies or reports on indigenous systems in the Arsi Zone. Document review will provide context and may help validate or triangulate findings from interviews and surveys.

3.5 Research Instrument Design and Questionnaire Format and Ordering

This section elaborates the research instrument design for the quantitative component of this mixed methods study. The primary research instrument for quantitative data collection is a structured household survey questionnaire. The construction of this research tool follows standard questionnaire design principles including logical flow, clarity of wording, appropriate question ordering (general to specific, less sensitive to more sensitive), and inclusion of different question types (closed-ended, Likert scale, and limited open-ended questions).

General Questionnaire Format

The questionnaire will be printed on A4 paper using a clear, readable font size of 12 point. Each page will include a header with the study title and a unique participant identification code. Questions will be numbered sequentially. Response options for closed-ended questions will be listed vertically rather than horizontally to reduce recording errors. Skip patterns will be clearly indicated using arrows and instructions such as "if yes go to question 15, if no go to question 17." Space will be provided after each section for enumerator notes.

The questionnaire will be produced in three language versions: English, Afan Oromo, and Amharic. The English version will serve as the master version. The Afan Oromo and Amharic versions will be prepared through translation and back-translation to ensure accuracy and cultural appropriateness.

Ordering of Questions in the Questionnaire

The questionnaire follows a logical sequence moving from general information to specific topics and from less sensitive to more sensitive questions. The ordering is as follows:

- [Section One](#): Screening and informed consent
- [Section Two](#): Household demographic information
- [Section Three](#): Household economic status
- [Section Four](#): Membership in indigenous mutual support systems (Iddir, Debo, Wonfel, Iqub)
- [Section Five](#): Welfare benefits received in past 12 months
- [Section Six](#): Perceptions of indigenous system effectiveness and challenges (Likert scale)
- [Section Seven](#): Relationship with formal social welfare services
- [Section Eight](#): Open-ended questions
- [Section Nine](#): Enumerator observations and closing

3.5.1 The Complete Structured Household Survey Questionnaire

Below is the complete structured household survey questionnaire organized exactly as it will be administered to the 280 sampled households.

Household Survey Questionnaire

Study Title: The Role of Indigenous Mutual Support Systems in Community Welfare

Research Institution: Arsi University, Dinsho Campus, Department of Sociology and Social Work

Participant Identification Code: _____

Enumerator Name: _____

Date of Interview: _____

Location (Urban Kebele or Rural Kebele): _____

Section One: Screening and Informed Consent

Question 1: Are you aged 18 years or older?

- Yes/ No (If No, thank the person and ask to speak with an adult household member aged 18 or older)

Question 2: Do you currently reside in this household as a usual member?

- Yes/ No (If No, thank the person and end the interview)

Question 3: The researcher has explained the purpose of this study, which is to understand the role of indigenous mutual support systems such as Iddir, Debo, Wonfel, and Iqub in community welfare. The researcher has explained that your participation is voluntary, that you can skip any question, and that your responses will be kept confidential. Do you agree to participate in this interview?

- Yes / No (If No, thank the person and end the interview)

Section Two: Household Demographic Information

Question 4: What is your gender?

- Male
- Female
- Other

Question 5: What is your age in years? _____ years

Question 6: What is your marital status?

- Never married
- Currently married
- Divorced or separated
- Widowed

Question 7: What is the highest level of education you have completed?

- No formal education
- Some primary school (grades 1-4)
- Completed primary school (grade 8)
- Some secondary school (grades 9-10)
- Completed secondary school (grade 12)
- Some college or university
- Completed college or university degree
- Post-graduate education

Question 8: What is your primary occupation?

- Farming
- Daily laborer
- Small trade or business
- Government employee

- Private sector employee
- Housewife or homemaker
- Student
- Unemployed looking for work
- Unemployed not looking for work
- Retired
- Other (please specify): _____

Question 9: If you have additional sources of income beyond your primary occupation, please list them:

Question 10: Including yourself, how many people live in this household? _____ persons

Question 11: How many children under the age of 18 years live in this household? _____ children

Section Three: Household Economic Status

Question 12: What is the approximate total monthly income of your household from all sources?

- Less than 1000 Ethiopian Birr
- 1000-1999 Birr
- 2000-2999 Birr
- 3000-3999 Birr
- 4000-4999 Birr
- 5000-5999 Birr
- 6000-6999 Birr
- 7000-7999 Birr
- 8000-8999 Birr
- 9000-9999 Birr
- 10000 Birr or more

Question 13: Does your household own any of the following assets? (Yes/No for each)

- Mobile phone
- Radio

- Television
- Bicycle
- Motorcycle or Bajaj
- Farm animals (cattle, goats, sheep, chickens)
- Cart
- Sewing machine
- Electric stove or oven
- Refrigerator
- Car

Question 14: What type of housing does your household occupy?

- Privately owned home
- Rented home
- Shared family home
- Temporary shelter

Question 15: What is the main construction material of your house?

- Stone and cement
- Mud and wood
- Iron sheet
- Thatched roof and mud wall

Question 16: In the past 30 days, has there been any day when your household went without food because of lack of money or other resources?

- Never
- 1-2 days
- 3-5 days
- 6-10 days
- More than 10 days

Section Four: Membership in Indigenous Mutual Support Systems

This section asks about your membership in four types of traditional community support systems. Please answer for each system separately.

Iddir (funeral and emergency support association)

Question 17: Are you currently a member of an Iddir?

- Yes / No (If No, skip to Question

Question 18: How many years have you been a member of any Iddir?

- Less than 1 year
- 1-3 years
- 4-6 years
- 7-10 years
- More than 10 years

Question 19: How often do you participate in Iddir meetings or activities?

- Always (nearly every meeting)
- Often (about 3/4 of meetings)
- Sometimes (about half of meetings)
- Rarely (about 1/4 of meetings)
- Never

Question 20: What types of contributions do you make to your Iddir? (Select all that apply)

- Monthly cash payment
- Contribution in kind (food, coffee during meetings)
- Labor during funerals
- Other (please specify): _____

Question 21: What benefits have you received from your Iddir membership in the past 12 months? (Select all that apply)

- Cash assistance for funeral of family member
- Cash assistance for other emergency
- Labor at funeral

- Food or refreshments during ceremonies
- Emotional support and condolence visits
- Other (please specify): _____

Debo (labor sharing system among farming families)

Question 22: Are you currently a member or participant in a Debo labor sharing arrangement?

- Yes/ No (If No, skip to Question 27)

Question 23: How many years have you participated in Debo?

- Less than 1 year
- 1-3 years
- 4-6 years
- 7-10 years
- More than 10 years

Question 24: During the last agricultural season, approximately how many days of Debo labor did you receive from others?

- 0 days
- 1-5 days
- 6-10 days
- 11-15 days
- 16-20 days
- More than 20 days

Question 25: During the last agricultural season, approximately how many days of Debo labor did you provide to others?

- 0 days
- 1-5 days
- 6-10 days
- 11-15 days
- 16-20 days

- More than 20 days

Question 26: What benefits beyond labor exchange have you received from Debo participation? (Select all that apply)

- Shared food or drink during work days
- Strengthened friendship and social ties
- Access to farming tools or oxen through network
- Information about farming techniques
- Other (please specify): _____

Wonfel (large-scale collective work party)

Question 27: Are you currently a participant in Wonfel activities?

- Yes/ No (If No, skip to Question

Question 28: Approximately how many Wonfel events did you participate in during the last 12 months?

- 0 events
- 1-2 events
- 3-4 events
- 5-6 events
- 7 or more events

Question 29: In Wonfel, do you typically serve as a host (receives collective labor), a participant (provides labor to others), or both?

- Usually host
- Usually participant
- Both equally

Question 30: What types of activities does your Wonfel typically perform? (Select all that apply)

- Plowing or land preparation
- Planting or sowing
- Weeding
- Harvesting

- House construction
- Other (please specify): _____

Question 31: What benefits do you value most from Wonfel participation? (Rank top 3, with 1 = most valuable)

- Completing large tasks quickly
- Reducing need to hire paid labor
- Social celebration and food sharing
- Strengthening community ties
- Learning new skills from neighbors

Iqub (rotating savings and credit association)

Question 32: Are you currently a member of an Iqub?

- Yes/ No (If No, skip to Question 38)

Question 33: How many Iqub groups do you currently participate in?

- 1 group
- 2 groups
- 3 groups
- 4 or more groups

Question 34: What is your typical monthly contribution to your Iqub?

- Less than 100 Birr
- 100-199 Birr
- 200-299 Birr
- 300-399 Birr
- 400-499 Birr
- 500-599 Birr
- 600-699 Birr
- 700-799 Birr
- 800-899 Birr

· 900-999 Birr

· 1000 Birr or more

Question 35: Have you received your rotation payout within the past 12 months?

· Yes · No (If No, skip to Question 37)

Question 36: How did you use the Iqub payout you received? (Select all that apply)

· Paid for medical expenses

· Paid for school fees

· Purchased food or household goods

· Made home repairs or improvements

· Invested in business or farming

· Paid for wedding or funeral ceremony

· Other (please specify): _____

Question 37: What is your primary reason for joining an Iqub rather than using a bank or microfinance institution? (Select the most important reason)

· Iqub does not require paperwork or documentation

· Iqub does not charge interest

· I trust Iqub members more than formal institutions

· Iqub is more flexible with payment schedules

· I can join with very small contributions

· I do not have access to a bank

Section Five: Welfare Benefits Received in the Past 12 Months

Question 38: In the past 12 months, have you received cash assistance from any indigenous support system (Iddir, Iqub payout, or other system)?

· Yes / No

· If Yes, approximately what was the total cash amount received? _____ Ethiopian Birr

Question 39: In the past 12 months, have you received food or goods (grains, oil, sugar, clothing, etc.) from any indigenous support system?

· Yes / No

- If Yes, how many times did you receive such assistance? [] 1 time [] 2-3 times [] 4-5 times [] More than 5 times

Question 40: In the past 12 months, have you received labor assistance on your farm or home through Debo or Wonfel?

- Yes / No

- If Yes, approximately how many total days of labor did you receive? _____ days

Question 41: In the past 12 months, have you received access to credit or a lump sum through Iqub?

- Yes / No

- If Yes, what was the amount of credit received? _____ Ethiopian Birr

Question 42: Thinking about non-material benefits, please indicate whether you have experienced each of the following from your participation in indigenous systems in the past 12 months (Yes/No for each):

- Emotional support during a difficult time
- Advice or guidance on a personal problem
- A sense of belonging to a community
- Friendships that extended beyond system meetings
- Information about job or economic opportunities
- Help with childcare during emergencies
- Help with eldercare during emergencies

Question 43: Overall, how would you rate the importance of indigenous mutual support systems to your household wellbeing?

- Not at all important
- Slightly important
- Moderately important
- Very important
- Extremely important

Section Six: Perceptions of Indigenous System Effectiveness and Challenges

For each statement, indicate your level of agreement (1 = Strongly Disagree, 2 = Disagree, 3 = Neutral/Unsure, 4 = Agree, 5 = Strongly Agree)

Statement 1 2 3 4 5

44 The indigenous systems I participate in provide help when I need it most

45 The systems treat all members fairly regardless of wealth, gender, or social status

46 The contribution amounts required for membership are reasonable for my household

47 The leaders of these systems manage them well and fairly

48 Participation in these systems strengthens bonds between community members

49 The membership fees or contributions are sometimes difficult for my household to afford

50 Some community members are excluded from these systems unfairly

51 Younger people in our community are less interested in participating in traditional support systems compared to older generations

52 Formal government programs have reduced the need for traditional mutual support systems

53 Living in an urban area like Assela city has weakened mutual support compared to rural areas

Section Seven: Relationship with Formal Social Welfare Services

Question 54: In the past 12 months, has your household received any support from the following formal sources? (Yes/No for each)

- Government Productive Safety Net Program
- Government direct cash or food assistance
- NGO or charity organization
- Religious institution (church, mosque)
- Microfinance institution loan
- Other formal source (specify): _____

Question 55: Do you feel that formal social welfare services (government programs) coordinate or work together with indigenous systems (Iddir, Iqub) in your community?

- Yes, often
- Yes, sometimes

- Rarely
- Never
- I do not know

Question 56: Do you believe that formal social welfare services should partner more with indigenous mutual support systems to help community members?

- Yes, strongly agree
- Yes, somewhat agree
- Neutral
- No, somewhat disagree
- No, strongly disagree

Question 57: If formal services were to partner with indigenous systems, what kind of partnership would be most helpful? (Select the most important one)

- Providing funding or materials to indigenous systems
- Training indigenous system leaders in management or financial skills
- Referring clients to indigenous systems for certain types of support
- Inviting indigenous system leaders to planning meetings
- Recognizing and certifying indigenous systems officially

Section Eight: Open-Ended Questions

Question 58: Please share any additional information about your experience with indigenous mutual support systems that you feel is important but was not covered by the previous questions.

Question 59: What do you think could be done to strengthen indigenous mutual support systems in your community?

Question 60: Is there anything else you would like to tell us about community welfare or social support in your area?

Section Nine: Enumerator Observations and Closing

Question 61: Date of interview completion: _____

Question 62: Time interview started: _____ AM/PM

Question 63: Time interview ended: _____ AM/PM

Question 64: Participant cooperation level:

- Very cooperative and engaged
- Cooperative but reserved
- Somewhat reluctant but completed
- Very reluctant and uncooperative

Question 65: Any problems encountered during this interview (language difficulties, interruptions, participant confusion)?

Question 66: Any follow-up needed (returning to collect missing information or verify responses)?

- Yes/ No
- If Yes, describe: _____

Question 67: Enumerator confirmation: I confirm that I have read the informed consent statement to the participant, that the participant agreed to participate voluntarily, and that the participant understood that they could skip questions or withdraw at any time.

Enumerator Signature: _____

Thank you for your participation in this important study.

3.6 Data Analysis Plan

The data analysis plan has separate components for quantitative and qualitative data followed by integration of the two.

For quantitative data from the household survey, data will be entered into SPSS version 26 for Windows. Data cleaning will be conducted to check for missing values, outliers, and entry errors. Descriptive statistics (frequencies, percentages, means, medians, standard deviations) will be calculated for all variables to describe the sample and the distribution of key indicators.

Bivariate analysis will be conducted using cross-tabulations with chi-square tests for categorical variables and independent samples t-tests or ANOVA for continuous variables to examine relationships between membership in indigenous systems and welfare outcomes.

Multivariate analysis will be conducted using multiple linear regression with household welfare index score as the dependent variable and membership status, demographic controls, and other relevant independent variables. Hypotheses H1-H5 will be tested at $p < 0.05$ significance level.

Excel will be used for basic data organization and for creating simple charts and graphs to visualize key quantitative findings (membership rates across systems, types of benefits received).

For qualitative data from in-depth interviews, focus groups, and open-ended survey questions, we will use thematic analysis following the six-phase approach developed by Braun and Clarke:

Phase 1 (Familiarization): Transcribing all audio recordings verbatim, translating content to English for analysis when necessary, reading all transcripts multiple times while making initial notes.

Phase 2 (Generating initial codes): Systematically working through each transcript and marking segments of text that relate to the research questions.

Phase 3 (Searching for themes): Collating codes into potential themes by identifying patterns and grouping related codes.

Phase 4 (Reviewing themes): Checking that themes are coherent, distinct, and accurately represent the data; refining theme definitions.

Phase 5 (Defining and naming themes): Writing a detailed description of each theme including its scope, core content, and relationships.

Phase 6 (Producing the report): Writing up qualitative findings with rich description and illustrative quotes.

The qualitative analysis will be conducted manually (without software) given the manageable volume of data and the researchers' preference for hands-on engagement.

Integration of quantitative and qualitative findings will occur during the interpretation phase. We will compare findings side by side for each major research question, examining convergence, divergence, and how qualitative findings explain or contextualize quantitative patterns.

3.7 Ethical Considerations

As social work students, we are committed to conducting ethical research that respects participants, does no harm, and benefits the community.

Informed consent will be obtained from all participants. We will explain the research purpose, procedures, risks, benefits, confidentiality protections, and voluntary nature of participation in the participant's preferred language. Written consent will be obtained using a consent form approved by the Arsi University Department of Sociology and Social Work. For participants who cannot read, the consent form will be read aloud and verbal consent will be documented by a witness.

Confidentiality will be protected. No real names will be used in any report or publication. Participants will be identified by codes (e.g., "Survey Participant 45" or "Iddir Leader 3"). All data (surveys, audio recordings, transcripts) will be stored in a locked cabinet or password-protected computer accessible only to the research team.

Anonymity cannot be guaranteed in focus group settings because participants will see each other. This limitation will be explained during the consent process, and focus group participants will be asked to agree to keep discussions confidential.

Do no harm is our primary ethical principle. Questions will be asked sensitively, avoiding stigma about poverty or exclusion. Participants will be reminded that they can skip any question or withdraw at any time without negative consequences. If a participant becomes distressed, the interview or focus group will

be paused and the participant will be offered referral to available support services. While there is no direct financial compensation, participants will receive information about the study findings if they wish, and the research aims to produce recommendations.

Benefit to participants and community is an important one that can strengthen indigenous support systems and improve social work practice. We will also provide small refreshments during focus groups as a courtesy.

Institutional approval will be obtained from the Arsi University Department of Sociology and Social Work before any data collection begins. Permission will also be obtained from the Assela City Administration and relevant kebele offices.

Data storage and destruction plan: All paper surveys will be stored in a locked filing cabinet for 3 years after study completion. Audio recordings will be stored on a password-protected computer and deleted after transcription is verified. Electronic data (SPSS files) will be anonymized and stored for 5 years, accessible only to the principal researchers. After the retention period, all data will be permanently deleted or shredded.

Conflict of interest statement: The researchers declare no financial or personal conflicts of interest in conducting this study. The research is conducted solely for academic purposes as a student assignment. No external funding has been received that would influence the design, analysis, or reporting of results.

PROPOSED ROLES AND RESPONSIBILITIES OF RESEARCH TEAM MEMBERS

Horsa Gowe (Principal Coordinator) • Coordinate overall research activities. • Supervise data collection and field operations. • Ensure research objectives are achieved. • Compile and submit the final report.

Muaz Baro (Literature Review Coordinator) • Update and review relevant literature. • Assist in theoretical and conceptual framework development. • Support report writing and referencing.

Hewan Demisse (Survey Team Leader) • Coordinate household survey activities. • Monitor questionnaire administration. • Ensure data quality during fieldwork.

Tenaye Tesefaye (Community Liaison Officer) • Communicate with community leaders and participants. • Facilitate access to study sites. • Assist in participant recruitment.

Tihitna Zinabu (Interview Coordinator) • Organize and conduct in-depth interviews. • Prepare interview schedules. • Support qualitative data collection.

Rohobot Reta (Focus Group Coordinator) • Organize focus group discussions. • Facilitate participant engagement. • Maintain discussion records and notes.

Kalid Mohammed (Data Management Officer) • Manage survey data entry. • Organize databases and records. • Assist in statistical analysis using SPSS.

Mihret Geleta (Ethics and Documentation Officer) • Monitor ethical compliance during research. • Manage consent forms and confidentiality procedures. • Maintain research documentation.

Oliyad Hayilu (Logistics and Budget Officer) • Coordinate transportation and field logistics. • Monitor budget utilization. • Manage research materials and supplies.

Abreham Bechere (Report and Presentation Coordinator) • Assist in report writing and editing. • Prepare tables, figures, and presentation materials. • Coordinate dissemination of findings.

3.8 Pilot Study and Validation

A pilot study will be conducted before full data collection to test and refine research instruments and procedures. The pilot will involve administering the household survey to thirty households not included in the main sample, conducting two practice in-depth interviews, and conducting one practice focus group discussion. The pilot will assess question clarity, survey length, translation accuracy, cultural appropriateness of wording, interviewer consistency, and logistical feasibility. Based on pilot feedback, instruments and procedures will be revised.

For validation, we will use multiple strategies:

Triangulation: Comparing findings across data sources (surveys, interviews, focus groups, documents)

Member checking: Returning to a subset of participants (approx. 5 interview participants + 1 focus group) to present preliminary findings and ask whether our interpretations accurately reflect their views

Peer debriefing: Discussing emerging findings with fellow students and academic advisor to check for bias or alternative explanations

Reflexivity: Research team maintaining a reflective journal documenting our own assumptions, positionality, and how our identities as university students may affect data collection and interpretation

CHAPTER FOUR: PROJECT DESIGN AND IMPLEMENTATION PLAN

4.1 Research Implementation Phases

The research will be implemented in four phases over a total of six months.

Phase One: Preparation and Instrument Development (1 month)

- Finalizing research proposal
- Obtaining ethical approval and institutional permissions
- Developing and piloting household survey questionnaire
- Developing in-depth interview guide and focus group discussion guide
- Translating all instruments to Afan Oromo and Amharic
- Training research assistants on data collection procedures and ethics
- Identifying and contacting kebele administration offices to obtain household lists

Phase Two: Quantitative Data Collection (2 months)

- Selecting stratified random sample of 280 households using kebele household lists

· Conducting face-to-face household surveys with trained enumerators · Conducting daily quality checks on completed surveys · Entering survey data into SPSS · Conducting initial descriptive analysis
Phase Three: Qualitative Data Collection (2 months) · Recruiting purposive sample (20 in-depth interview participants; 32-40 focus group participants) · Scheduling and conducting interviews and focus groups · Transcribing audio recordings verbatim · Translating transcripts to English as needed · Conducting initial thematic analysis concurrently with data collection
Phase Four: Data Analysis and Report Writing (1 month) · Completing quantitative data analysis (bivariate and multivariate statistics) · Completing qualitative thematic analysis · Integrating quantitative and qualitative findings · Drafting research report (findings, discussion, recommendations) · Presenting preliminary findings at stakeholder meeting (community members + social welfare professionals) for feedback · Finalizing report

4.2 Budget Framework and Resource Mobilization Strategy

The research will be implemented with a minimal budget leveraging in-kind contributions from the research team and university support.

Category Item Estimated Cost (ETB)

Start-up Costs

Printing (surveys, consent forms, documents) 500

Audio recording equipment (2 digital voice recorders) 2,000

Stationery (notebooks, pens, folders) 300

Calculator and data storage devices (USB drives) 400

Subtotal 3,200

Operational Costs

Transportation (enumerators, researchers) - 2 months 2,400

Communication (mobile airtime) - 2 months 800

Refreshments for focus group participants (4 groups) 1,200

Transcription and translation assistance (if hired) 2,000

Contingency fund (unexpected expenses) 1,000

Subtotal 7,400

TOTAL 10,600

Resource Mobilization Strategy:

In-kind contributions from research team (volunteer time, personal stationery)

Request for small grant support from Arsi University Community Service Fund or Department research budget

Potential support from Assela City Administration (providing household lists, facilitating community access)

Group member contributions for minimal expenses not covered elsewhere

4.3 Monitoring, Evaluation, and Learning Framework

We will track research progress using simple monitoring tools:

Weekly research team meetings to review progress against work plan, discuss challenges, make adjustments

Daily log for survey completion (households approached, completions, refusals, non-response reasons)

Qualitative data collection log tracking interviews/focus groups completed, recording quality, emerging themes

Quality assurance:

- 10% random check of surveys for completeness and accuracy
- Regular debriefing sessions with enumerators to address questions or problems
- Audio review of a sample of interviews to assess interviewer adherence to the guide

Learning and adaptation: If a sampling strategy proves ineffective or a data collection method is not working as anticipated, adjustments will be made and documented.

CHAPTER FIVE: ANTICIPATED OUTCOMES, RECOMMENDATIONS, AND CONCLUSION

5.1 Anticipated Outcomes

Based on the research design, we anticipate several categories of outcomes from this study.

Empirical outcomes will include:

A detailed description of current structures, membership patterns, and operational mechanisms of Iddir, Debo, Wonfel, and Iqub in Assela City and surrounding rural kebeles

Variations in system functioning between urban and rural contexts and between different system types

Specific welfare benefits that members receive (material and non-material)

Major challenges confronting indigenous systems (urbanization, economic change, youth migration, interactions with formal institutions)

Diverse community and professional perceptions of the relationship between indigenous systems and formal welfare services (complementary vs. tension/competition)

Practical outcomes will include evidence-based recommendations for social workers and policymakers on effective collaboration with indigenous mutual support systems, addressing: assessment strategies; partnership models respecting autonomy; capacity strengthening approaches; and referral pathways.

Academic outcomes will include:

A mixed methods research report suitable for submission to a departmental journal or university research day presentation

A dataset on indigenous mutual support systems in the Arsi Zone for future comparative research

A demonstration of how mixed methods research can be conducted by undergraduate students with limited resources

5.2 Recommendations for Social Work Practice (Anticipated)

Based on the anticipated findings, we will develop recommendations for social work practice at multiple levels.

At the assessment level: Social workers conducting community needs assessments should routinely map indigenous mutual support systems as community assets rather than focusing only on deficits and formal services. Assessment tools should include questions about community members' participation in Iddir, Debo, Wonfel, Iqub, and similar systems.

At the intervention level: Social workers should consider how their interventions can support rather than disrupt indigenous systems. This may involve: referring clients to indigenous systems for certain types of

support; collaborating with system leaders to identify vulnerable members needing additional help; or providing training to system leaders on conflict resolution or financial management if requested.

At the policy level: The Assela City Administration and Oromia Regional Social Affairs Bureau should recognize indigenous mutual support systems as legitimate partners in community welfare and create mechanisms for collaboration, such as: including system leaders in welfare planning meetings; providing small grants or in-kind support to systems; and removing regulatory barriers that impede system functioning.

5.3 Recommendations for Future Research

This study will identify areas for future research:

A longitudinal study tracking changes in indigenous mutual support systems over time to understand adaptation and resilience

A comparative study examining indigenous systems across multiple regions of Oromia to identify context-specific variations and transferable lessons

An intervention study testing different models of social work collaboration with indigenous systems to generate evidence on what works under what conditions

A study specifically focused on excluded populations to understand who is not served by indigenous systems and why

5.4 Conclusion

This research proposal has presented a mixed methods study designed to examine the role of indigenous mutual support systems (Iddir, Debo, Wonfel, and Iqub) in community welfare in Assela City and surrounding rural kebeles from a social work perspective.

The proposal began with the observation that while these indigenous systems have existed for centuries and continue to function in contemporary Ethiopia, there is limited systematic understanding of their current role, effectiveness, and relationship with formal social welfare services. Using a convergent parallel mixed methods design combining a household survey of 280 randomly selected households with in-depth interviews and focus group discussions, this research aims to describe the structures and benefits of indigenous systems, identify challenges they face, explore community and professional perceptions, and develop evidence-based recommendations for culturally competent social work practice.

The research is grounded in social capital theory, indigenization of social work theory, and systems theory, and it prioritizes ethical principles of informed consent, confidentiality, and benefit to the community. The research instrument design includes a detailed 67-question structured survey organized into nine logical sections moving from demographic information through membership patterns, benefits received, perceptions, and open-ended feedback. Quantitative data will be analyzed using SPSS version 26 for Windows with descriptive statistics, bivariate analysis, and multiple linear regression to test five stated hypotheses. Qualitative data will be analyzed using thematic analysis.

The anticipated outcomes include empirical documentation of indigenous systems in the Arsi Zone, practical recommendations for social workers, and a demonstration of how mixed methods research can be conducted by undergraduate students. The success of this research depends on the willingness of community members to share their experiences and the commitment of the research team to conduct the study with rigor, respect, and cultural sensitivity.

As sociology and social work students at Arsi University, we believe that understanding and supporting indigenous mutual support systems is not only academically important but also professionally and personally meaningful. These systems represent the resilience, generosity, and collective wisdom of our communities. We hope this research will contribute to strengthening them.

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APPENDICES

- *Appendix A: In-Depth Interview Guide for System Leaders*
- *Appendix B: In-Depth Interview Guide for Community Elders*
- *Appendix C: In-Depth Interview Guide for Social Welfare Professionals*
- *Appendix D: Focus Group Discussion Guide*
- *Appendix E: Informed Consent Form (Afan Oromo, Amharic, and English versions)*
- *Appendix F: Detailed Budget Spreadsheet*
- *Appendix G: Research Timeline (Gantt Chart)*